Create.IT

Usability Testing Document

Interface Evaluation & Shortened UEQ Analysis

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Contents

1. Introduction 3
1.1 Purpose of this document 3
1.2 What was tested 3
1.3 Method summary 4
2. Testing Methodology 4
2.1 Participant profile 4
2.2 Test environment 4
2.3 Protocol 4
2.4 Tasks 5
2.5 Capture template 5
UEQ Questionnaire 5
3. Individual User Feedback 6
3.1 Participant 1 6
UEQ scores 7
Debrief: 7
3.2 Participant 2 8
UEQ scores 9
Debrief 9
UEQ scores 11
Debrief 11
UEQ scores 12
Debrief 13
4. Aggregated Results 14
4.1 Task completion summary 14
Observation 14
4.2 Task duration comparison 14
Observations: 14
4.3 UEQ aggregated scores 15
5. Interpretation of Results 19
6. Recommended Improvements 22
6.1 High priority 22
6.2 Medium priority 23

7. Conclusion 25
Appendices 27
Appendix A - Observation sheet used 27

1. Introduction

1.1 Purpose of this document

This document reports the findings of a usability test conducted on Create.IT, our online multimedia course platform prototype. The test was run as part of Group Design D, which requires us to take our designed web system and evaluate its interface through real-user testing using the UEQ shortened questionnaire.

The goal of this test was not to prove that the site works. The goal was to observe how real users approach the tasks the platform is designed for, where they hesitate, what they expect to happen that does not happen, and where the design either succeeds or fails them. From these observations, we identify pain points and propose improvements to inform the final submission.

1.2 What was tested

Create.IT is a front-end prototype of an online learning platform. It includes:

- Account login and registration
- A browsable course catalogue with filtering and search
- Individual course detail pages with syllabus and instructor information
- Cart and demo checkout
- A student learning dashboard with course progression
- A Customer Experience hub with purchase history, support FAQs, and course reviews
- A certificate system for course completion
- Three deliberately designed emotional peaks
    1. An enrolment celebration
    2. Milestone feedback during lessons
    3. A certificate ceremony on course completion.

1.3 Method summary

Four participants were recruited. Each participant was given five realistic tasks to complete, asked to think out loud throughout, and observed by one of our group members as the facilitator, and one as a note-taker. After the tasks, each participant completed a shortened UEQ questionnaire covering eight paired qualities on a seven-point scale.

2. Testing Methodology

2.1 Participant profile

Four participants were tested. All were University of Pretoria students with varied prior experience using online course platforms. Participants were assigned codes P1 through P4 and were anonymised in this document.

2.2 Test environment

All tests were run during a session at the co-labs with the team and the four participants. Participants used our dedicated laptop to access the development build of Create.IT at http://localhost:5173/. Each session lasted approximately 15 minutes. A facilitator read the script aloud, and a note-taker recorded observations. No audio or video was recorded; only written notes were taken.

2.3 Protocol

Each session followed the same protocol:

1. Introduction
The facilitator read a short script explaining that the test measured the design, not the participant, and that participation was voluntary.

2. Warm-up
The participant was asked about their prior experience with online course platforms.

3. Task phase
The participant attempted the five tasks (mentioned below) one at a time, thinking out loud. The facilitator did not help unless the participant was completely stuck for more than 60 seconds.

4. UEQ questionnaire
After the tasks, the participant completed the shortened UEQ questionnaire.

5. Debrief
The facilitator asked three closing questions: what confused them, what surprised them positively, and what they would change.

2.4 Tasks

The five tasks were designed to test the core journeys of the platform without prescribing how to complete them.

1. Find a course on motion graphics and describe what you would be learning
2. Add that course to the cart and complete the checkout
3. Find where to see the courses you have enrolled in
4. Track your progress on a course and continue where you left off
5. Get your certificate after finishing a course

2.5 Capture template

The following template was used to capture observations from each participant during each task.

[Appendix A - Observation sheet used]
(can be found at the end of this document.)

Then after completing the five tasks, each participant completed the following UEQ questionnaire.

UEQ Questionnaire

obstructive	o o o o o o o	supportive
complicated	o o o o o o o	easy
inefficient	o o o o o o o	efficient
confusing	o o o o o o o	clear
boring	o o o o o o o	exciting
not interesting	o o o o o o o	interesting
conventional	o o o o o o o	inventive
usual	o o o o o o o	leading edge

3. Individual User Feedback

This section reports the observations for each participant, task by task. Each subsection includes task timing, outcome, first action, hesitations, verbatim quotes, and any additional notes we captured. The four UEQ questionnaires completed by each participant are also included in the feedback below.

3.1 Participant 1

Task 1 - Find a motion graphics course

Field	Observation
Duration	1 minute
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Motion Graphics" category in the left sidebar
Hesitations	Briefly paused on the catalogue page. Was unsure whether to use the search bar or the sidebar categories, then chose the sidebar.
Verbatim	"Okay, these are the motion courses. This first one looks popular. I'll click 'Syllabus & Info' to learn more."
Notes	On the detail page, they found "Course Overview & Studio Objectives" and "Structured Curriculum & Modules" easily.

Task 2 - Add to cart and complete checkout

Field	Observation
Duration	1 minute
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked the green "Add to Cart" button, then clicked the cart icon in the header
Hesitations	Paused at "Complete Checkout & Enrol", expected a separate checkout button on a new page. In the checkout modal, read the summary then clicked "Confirm demo order".
Verbatim	"Oh, It just says 'Checkout successful'... wait, no, there's confetti! Okay, that's actually really nice. I didn't expect that. It feels like a reward for buying."
Notes	The celebration landed as a genuine peak. They briefly noted the absence of a payment step.

Task 3 - Find where to see enrolled courses

Field	Observation
Duration	15 seconds
Outcome	Completed
First action	Recognised the Student Learning Dashboard they were already on
Hesitations	None
Verbatim	"This is exactly what I expected to see. It's very clear."
Notes	Found the newly purchased course immediately.

Task 4 - Track progress / continue a course

Field	Observation
Duration	30 seconds

Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)"
Hesitations	None
Verbatim	"Wow! The bar moved and it said 'First Milestone (+25% progress)' That's a nice pop-up. I see the progress bar is now at 25%."
Notes	Noticed the toast. Understood the button as a progress simulation.

Task 5 - Get a certificate

Field	Observation
Duration	1 minute
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)" repeatedly to reach 100%
Hesitations	On reaching 100%, the only visible change was the toast. They paused and read it before noticing the new "View Certificate" button.
Verbatim	"Okay... 100%. Nothing happened. Wait, there's a little message. It says 'Progress updated to 0%'. Ok there's a new 'View Certificate' button. I'll click it. Oh wow, confetti.. That's fun."
Notes	Two issues surfaced. First, the toast at 100% reads "Progress updated to 0%", contradicting what the user just achieved. Second, the "View Certificate" button appeared without any announcement.

UEQ scores

obstructive	o o o o ● o o	supportive
complicated	o o o o ● o o	easy
inefficient	o o o o ● o o	efficient
confusing	o o ● o o o o	clear
boring	o o o o ● o o	exciting
not interesting	o o o o ● o o	interesting
conventional	o o o ● o o o	inventive
usual	o o o ● o o o	leading edge

Debrief:

Biggest confusion: The "Progress updated to 0%" toast at 100%. They briefly wondered whether they had reset their progress.

Biggest delight: The enrolment confetti on confirming the order. They also enjoyed the certificate confetti, once they found the button.

3.2 Participant 2

Task 1 - Find a motion graphics course

Field	Observation
Duration	30 seconds
Outcome	Completed
First action	Typed "motion" into the search bar
Hesitations	None. The search bar was the first element they looked for.
Verbatim	"The results are updating live. That's good. I'll click the title of this 'Cinema 4D & After Effects' course. I can see the description and what I'd learn right on this page. Done."
Notes	Found the course via search, not via sidebar categories.

Task 2 - Add to cart and complete checkout

Field	Observation
Duration	1 minute
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Add to Cart", noticed the header cart counter update, then clicked the cart button
Hesitations	In the cart view, paused expecting a payment form. In the checkout modal, scanned for a review step before clicking "Confirm demo order".
Verbatim	"Okay, confetti. That's a nice touch. It's a prototype, so I'll overlook the missing payment step. The celebration is cool though, I'd say that's the favourite thing so far."
Notes	Noted the absence of a simulated payment step as unrealistic, but was complimentary about the celebration.

Task 3 - Find where to see enrolled courses

Field	Observation
Duration	10 seconds
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "My Learning" in the sidebar
Hesitations	None
Verbatim	"And there's the course. I like the interface."

Task 4 - Track progress / continue a course

Field	Observation
Duration	20 seconds
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)"
Hesitations	None
Verbatim	"The progress bar updated. The toast is a nice touch. It's fine for a prototype, but having a video player to 'continue' where you left off would be more convincing."
Notes	Understood the button as a progress simulation tool. Suggested a course player would make the experience more realistic.

Task 5 - Get a certificate

Field	Observation
Duration	1 minute
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)" repeatedly to reach 100%
Hesitations	On the final click, noticed the toast before the new button. Read the toast, frowned, then found "View Certificate".
Verbatim	"Wait, 'Progress updated to 0%'? That's a bug. I just finished the course, and it says zero. Okay, and there's a 'View Certificate' button. I'll click it. Right, confetti, certificate, all good. But that toast is going to confuse people."
Notes	The toast bug was their most immediate finding and was flagged as report-worthy. The certificate modal itself worked without complaint.

UEQ scores

obstructive	o o o o● o o	supportive
complicated	o o o o o o●	easy
inefficient	o o o o● o o	efficient
confusing	o o o● o o o	clear
boring	o o o● o o o	exciting
not interesting	o o o● o o o	interesting
conventional	o o o● o o o	inventive
usual	o o o● o o o	leading edge

Debrief

Biggest confusion: The "Progress updated to 0%" toast at 100%.

Biggest delight: The enrolment celebration on confirming the order.

Standout quote: "That toast says 'Progress updated to 0%'. On completion. That's the first thing I'd fix."

3.3 Participant 3

Task 1 - Find a motion graphics course

Field	Observation
Duration	1 minute
Outcome	Completed
First action	Used the sidebar category filters and clicked "Motion Graphics"
Hesitations	On the course list, hesitated before clicking the "Curriculum" accordion button.
Verbatim	"I'll click 'Syllabus & Info' to see the full details. The description is good. I see the 'Curriculum' button expands the rows. That's a good micro-interaction, but I wonder if users expect it. It's not a standard pattern."
Notes	Flagged the expandable curriculum as a non-standard pattern that may need a clearer affordance.

Task 2 - Add to cart and complete checkout

Field	Observation
Duration	1 minute
Outcome	Completed
First action	Added to cart, opened the cart view, clicked "Complete Checkout & Enrol"
Hesitations	Deliberately read every line of the checkout modal before confirming. Was suspicious of the missing payment step.
Verbatim	"Oh nice..."
Notes	Complimentary about the placement of the enrolment celebration. Flagged the missing payment and confirmation steps as heuristic concerns for a real system.

Task 3 - Find where to see enrolled courses

Field	Observation
Duration	15 seconds
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "My Learning"
Hesitations	None
Verbatim	"This view is okay. The list is clear. The progress bars are a nice touch."
Duration	15 seconds

Task 4 - Track progress / continue a course

Field	Observation
Duration	30 seconds
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)"
Hesitations	None
Verbatim	"The UX feedback here is good. The progress bar, the toast notification... it's clear. However, the action is still just a progress increment. A 'Continue Lesson' button that launches a course player would be a more genuine 'continue where you left off' experience."
Notes	Appreciated the clear feedback but noted the interaction is a simplification of a real lesson flow.

Task 5 - Get a certificate

Field	Observation
Duration	1 minute
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)" until reaching 100%
Hesitations	Deliberately waited on the final click to see what would happen. Only the toast appeared. Read it and paused.
Verbatim	"So the end of the learning journey is a snackbar that says 'Progress updated to 0%'. The certificate itself, when I click 'View Certificate', is well designed."
Notes	Identified a design inconsistency: the enrolment celebration fires at the moment of commitment, but the completion flow does not celebrate the moment of finishing.

UEQ scores

obstructive	o o o ● o o o	supportive
complicated	o o o ● o o o	easy
inefficient	o o o ● o o o	efficient
confusing	o o ● o o o o	clear
boring	o o o ● o o o	exciting
not interesting	o o o o ● o o	interesting
conventional	o o o ● o o o	inventive
usual	o o o ● o o o	leading edge

Debrief

Biggest confusion: The "Progress updated to 0%" toast at 100%.

Biggest delight: The enrolment celebration, correctly placed at the moment of commitment.

Standout quote: "The end of the journey is a snack bar with the confusing number on it."

3.4 Participant 4

Task 1 - Find a motion graphics course

Field	Observation
Duration	2 minutes
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Explore Course Catalog" on the landing page
Hesitations	Overwhelmed by the catalog page at first. Scrolled up and down, looking at the sidebar, filters, and course cards before acting.
Verbatim	"Okay, so many options. I'll just click on the one that says 'Motion Graphics' in the filter. It's listed on the left. The course list updates. I'll click the first one. I can see the description here."
Notes	Slower to orient than the other three participants. The density of the catalog page caused an initial moment of hesitation.

Task 2 - Add to cart and complete checkout

Field	Observation
Duration	2 minutes
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Add to Cart", then the cart button, then "Complete Checkout & Enrol", then "Confirm demo order"
Hesitations	Spent time reading the toast message and looking at the cart item before clicking checkout. In the checkout modal, paused to read the summary.
Verbatim	"Oh that's cute. And it shows my course appearing. I like that. It makes it feel real."

Notes	The celebration was the moment that made the biggest impression. Without it, they said checkout would have felt abrupt.

Task 3 - Find where to see enrolled courses

Field	Observation
Duration	20 seconds
Outcome	Completed
First action	Recognised they were already on "My Learning"
Hesitations	None
Verbatim	"Okay, this is where my courses are."
Duration	20 seconds

Task 4 - Track progress / continue a course

Field	Observation
Duration	25 seconds
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)"
Hesitations	None
Verbatim	"The bar moved. It says I'm at 25% now."
Notes	Completed without comment.

Task 5 - Get a certificate

Field	Observation
Duration	2 minutes
Outcome	Completed
First action	Clicked the button three more times to reach 100%
Hesitations	Read the toast, looked at the card, then paused before clicking "View Certificate".
Verbatim	"It says 'Progress updated to 0%'. Did I do something wrong? Oh, no, the bar is full. Okay, there's 'View Certificate'. I'll click it. Okay, now it feels done."
Notes	The toast caused genuine momentary concern. Once they clicked through, the certificate modal resolved the confusion and landed well.

UEQ scores

obstructive	o o o o ● o o	supportive
complicated	o o o o ● o o	easy
inefficient	o o o ● o o o	efficient
confusing	o o ● o o o o	clear
boring	o o o o o o ●	exciting
not interesting	o o o o ● o o	interesting
conventional	o o o ● o o o	inventive
usual	o o o ● o o o	leading edge

Debrief

Biggest confusion: The "Progress updated to 0%" toast made them briefly worry they had done something wrong.

Biggest delight: The enrolment celebration on confirming the order.

Standout quote: "It said I went back to zero. That confused me for a second."

4. Aggregated Results

4.1 Task completion summary

All four participants completed all five tasks.

Task	P1	P2	P3	P4	Completed	Partial	Failed
1. Find motion graphics course	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	4	0	0
2. Cart and checkout	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	4	0	0
3. Find enrolled courses	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	4	0	0
4. Track and continue progress	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	4	0	0
5. Get certificate	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	4	0	0

Observation

Every task was completed by every participant. The platform is functionally usable across all the journeys tested. The value of the test, therefore, is not in identifying where users failed, but in identifying where they hesitated or where the design caused unnecessary friction.

4.2 Task duration comparison

Task	P1	P2	P3	P4	Average
1. Find motion graphics course	1:00	0:30	1:00	2:00	1:07
2. Cart and checkout	1:00	1:00	1:00	2:00	1:15
3. Find enrolled courses	0:15	0:10	0:15	0:20	0:15
4. Track and continue progress	0:30	0:20	0:30	0:25	0:26
5. Get certificate	1:00	1:00	1:00	2:00	1:15

Observations:

- Task 3 (finding enrolled courses) was consistently the fastest, at ~15 seconds average. All four participants found their way immediately, either because they were already on the dashboard or because the sidebar clearly labelled "My Learning".
- Task 1 (finding a course) averaged 1:07, with P4 taking twice as long as the fastest participant. This suggests the catalogue density is more of a barrier for less confident users.
- Tasks 2 and 5 both averaged 1:15. P4 was the slowest on both.
- Task 4 (tracking progress) averaged 26 seconds which is quick and consistent across participants.

4.3 UEQ aggregated scores

Pair	P1	P2	P3	P4	Mean
Obstructive / Supportive	5	5	4	5	**4.75**
Complicated / Easy	5	7	4	5	**5.25**
Inefficient / Efficient	5	5	4	4	**4.50**
Confusing / Clear	3	4	3	3	**3.25**
Boring / Exciting	5	4	4	7	**5.00**
Not interesting / Interesting	5	4	5	5	**4.75**
Conventional / Inventive	4	4	4	4	**4.00**
Usual / Leading edge	4	4	4	4	**4.00**

Pragmatic quality average (first 4 rows): 4.44
Hedonic quality average (last 4 rows): 4.44

4.4 Interpretation of the UEQ scores

Dimension	Mean	Interpretation
Supportive	4.75	Above neutral. Users felt the platform supported them.
Easy	5.25	Highest score in the pragmatic set. Users found the platform easy to use.
Efficient	4.50	Above neutral. Users could complete tasks without significant wasted effort.
Clear	3.25	Lowest score in the entire questionnaire. Users were not fully convinced that the interface was clear.

The pragmatic set averages 4.44 out of 7 are above neutral but not strong. The clear/confusing pair is a notable outlier at 3.25, which is below neutral. This is a meaningful finding: users could complete the tasks, but they did not always feel confident about what was happening or why.

This aligns with the observed friction in Task 5, the misleading toast at 100% progress, and the "View Certificate" button appearing without announcement.

Dimension	Mean	Interpretation
Exciting	5.00	Above neutral. The celebratory features generated positive affect.
Interesting	4.75	Above neutral.
Inventive	4.00	Neutral. Users did not see the platform as inventive.
Leading edge	4.00	Neutral. Users did not see the platform as leading edge.

The hedonic set also averages 4.44. The two "distinctiveness" dimensions (inventive and leading edge) are both exactly 4.00, meaning users viewed the platform as neither distinctive nor unoriginal. This matches the Group Design C finding from the competitor reviews: the whole category tends to be functional but not memorable.

The "exciting" dimension scored the highest in this set (5.00), and P4 rated it 7, the single highest score across the questionnaire. This suggests the celebration features do produce excitement, even if that excitement does not translate into a perception of the platform being overall inventive.

4.5 Recurring pain points

Issues observed or mentioned by two or more participants.

Pain point 1: The "Progress updated to 0%" toast at 100% progress

Frequency: Observed in all 4 participants

Description: When a user reaches 100% progress on an enrolled course, the toast message that appears reads "Progress updated to 0%" instead of a completion message. This is a direct contradiction of what the user has just achieved.

Impact: This is the single most damaging finding in the test. It causes users to doubt their own action at the exact moment they should be feeling accomplishment. It directly undermines the Peak-End design goal, since the peak of the learning journey ends in a contradictory message.

Severity: Critical. Fixing this is the single highest-value change to the prototype.

Pain point 2: The completion peak lacks ceremony at the moment of completion

Frequency: Observed in P1, P3, and P4 (three of four participants).

Description: When a user completes a course, the only in-page feedback is the toast (see Pain point 1) and the appearance of a new "View Certificate" button on the card. The certificate ceremony itself, confetti, congratulations header, shimmer, only fires when the user clicks that button. The peak is therefore delayed by one click, and the moment of completion feels anticlimactic.

Impact: Users experience their strongest positive reaction at checkout (Peak 1) rather than at course completion (the intended End peak). This weakens the Peak-End design, because the end of the journey should be the most memorable moment, not the middle.

Severity: High. The fix is small: fire the certificate ceremony immediately when progress reaches 100%, rather than waiting for a button click.

Pain point 3: Catalogue density creates hesitation for less confident users

Frequency: Observed in P1 and P4 (two of four participants).

Description: Both P1 and P4 hesitated on the catalogue page, unsure whether to use the search bar or the sidebar categories. P4 took twice as long to complete Task 1 and described the page as having "so many options".

Impact: The catalogue is functional but dense. Users who are comfortable with online platforms (P2, P3) navigate it instantly. Users who are less confident (P4) hesitate. This suggests the catalogue needs a clearer primary action such as a "start here" pattern.

Severity: Medium. Not a blocker, but a real friction point for a portion of users.

Pain point 4: Non-standard patterns cause friction (minor)

Frequency: Observed in P3.

Description: P3 questioned the "Curriculum" accordion button on the course detail page, saying it was not a standard pattern. P3 also questioned the absence of a payment step at checkout (though acknowledged it was a prototype).

Impact: Low-level friction, not a completion barrier.

Severity: Low. Informational.

4.6 Recurring positive moments

Positive reactions shared by two or more participants.

Positive moment 1: The enrolment celebration

Frequency: Observed in all 4 participants.

Description: All four participants explicitly commented on the confetti celebration that fires after completing checkout.

Interpretation: The enrolment celebration is the strongest peak in the current design. It is placed at a genuine moment of commitment, and it produces a visible emotional response. This validates the Peak-End design intent, but also highlights the gap at course completion (see Pain point 2).

Positive moment 2: Clear navigation in the sidebar

Frequency: Observed in all 4 participants.

Description: All four participants found their way to "My Learning" and to the enrolled course within 15–20 seconds, without hesitation.

Interpretation: The sidebar's "My Learning" entry is well-labelled and clear. The navigation between the major sections of the platform works as intended.

Positive moment 3: Clear progress feedback

Frequency: Observed in P1, P3, and P4.

Description: When participants clicked "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)", they noticed the progress bar animating and the milestone toast appearing. The feedback was read and understood.

Interpretation: The milestone feedback works as a smaller peak within the learning journey. Even though these sub-peaks are less intense than the enrolment celebration, they are noticed and appreciated. The implication is that the milestone feedback strategy is sound but would benefit from being paired with a stronger completion moment.

5. Interpretation of Results

5.1 What worked

Three aspects of the design performed strongly across the test sessions.

1. The enrolment celebration

   All four participants explicitly reacted to the confetti celebration that fires after completing checkout. Their responses ranged from delight ("that's the favourite thing so far") to a clear sense of completion ("it makes it feel real"). The celebration appears at exactly the moment the user has made a commitment, completing a purchase, and this placement is what makes it effective. It gives the user a reward at the moment they would expect one, and it validates the decision they just made.

   This finding confirms that the Peak-End design intent is working at the enrolment moment. The client's brief specifically asked for "checking out a course" to stand out, and the test evidence shows it does.

2. Sidebar navigation to My Learning

   All four participants found their way to the student learning dashboard within 15–20 seconds, without hesitation. The "My Learning" label in the left sidebar was immediately understood, and the enrolled course was visible the moment the user arrived.

   This is significant because it shows that the primary navigation pattern works. Users do not need to guess where to find their courses. This directly supports the design principle of avoiding clutter on detail-heavy pages, the sidebar is uncluttered and each entry has a clear purpose.

3. Progress feedback at the milestone level

   The milestone feedback on lesson completion, the animating progress bar and the toast message, was noticed and read by three of the four participants. The interactions were understood as progress updates, and the toasts were read without confusion. This is a smaller peak than the enrolment celebration, but it works.

   This validates the design principle of rewarding milestones, not just the finish. The design successfully treats mid-journey progress as a moment worth acknowledging.

5.2 What needs improvement

Four pain points emerged. Two are critical or high severity; two are lower-level friction.

Pain point 1: The misleading toast at 100% progress

Frequency: All four participants.

Severity: Critical.

When a course reaches 100% progress, the toast message reads "Progress updated to 0%". This is the single most damaging finding in the test. Every participant noticed it. Three of the four interpreted it as a bug. One thought they had broken something. All of them momentarily doubted their own action at the exact moment the design should be producing its strongest positive reaction.

This failure has two consequences:

1. It undermines the completion peak. The Peak-End Rule states that the end of a journey dominates memory. Instead of ending on a message of accomplishment, the learning journey ends on a message of contradiction. Users will remember that moment.
2. It causes them to distrust the progress tracking. Progress bars are meant to be reliable. A message that contradicts them damages the credibility of the whole system.

The fix is small. The message is likely generated from a stale state value or a formula that resets when progress hits the maximum. Replacing it with a completion message ("Course complete!") would resolve the issue entirely.

Pain point 2: The completion peak lacks ceremony

Frequency: Three of four participants.

Severity: High.

When a course is completed, the only in-page feedback is the toast (see Pain point 1) and the appearance of a new "View Certificate" button on the course card. The certificate ceremony itself, confetti, congratulations header, shimmer, only fires when the user clicks that button. The peak is therefore delayed by one click, and the moment of completion feels anticlimactic.

This finding is important because it reveals an asymmetry in the design. The enrolment celebration fires at the moment of commitment. The completion moment does not follow the same pattern. The result is that users experience their strongest positive reaction at checkout rather than at course completion,

which is the wrong ordering, given that completion is the natural end of the journey.

The fix is small and consistent with existing patterns: fire the certificate ceremony immediately when progress reaches 100%, rather than waiting for a button click. The design already contains the ceremony; it just needs to be triggered earlier.

Pain point 3: Catalogue density causes hesitation

Frequency: Two of four participants.

Severity: Medium.

Two participants hesitated on the catalogue page, unsure whether to use the search bar or the sidebar category filters. The catalogue presents many options at once, a search bar, a sidebar with filters, a category pill row, sort controls, and a full list of courses, and this density is a barrier for less confident users.

Users who are comfortable with online platforms navigate it instantly. Users who are less confident hesitate. The lesson is not that the catalogue should be simpler, but that it needs a clearer primary action, a "start here" pattern that shows the user where to look first.

This is a real friction point, but it does not block task completion. It is a polish-level improvement rather than a critical fix.

Pain point 4: Non-standard patterns

Frequency: One participant.

Severity: Low.

One participant questioned two design decisions:

- The "Curriculum" accordion button on the course detail page ("not a standard pattern")
- The absence of a payment step in the checkout flow

Neither blocked the user, and the participant acknowledged that the second was a prototype limitation. But the feedback is useful: it shows that unfamiliar UI patterns require more explicit affordances, and that the absence of a payment step should be more clearly framed as a prototype behaviour.

6. Recommended Improvements

Based on the observations across four participants, the following improvements are recommended for the final submission.

6.1 High priority

Changes that address pain points experienced by multiple participants and directly affect the experience.

1. Fix the completion toast message

    What to change: When a user reaches 100% progress on a course, the toast currently reads "Progress updated to 0%". This should be replaced with a message that reflects what has actually happened, for example, "Course complete!" or "You finished this course."

    Why: All four participants noticed this message. Three of them interpreted it as a bug, and one thought they had broken the progress tracking. This is the single most damaging finding in the test. It contradicts the user's achievement at the exact moment the design should be producing its strongest positive reaction. It also undermines trust in the progress bar itself.

    Evidence: P1: "For a second I thought I'd broken it." P2: "That's a bug... on completion." P3: "The end of the journey is a snackbar with the confusing number on it." P4: "Did I do something wrong?"

    Effort: Small. This is likely a single string change in the completion handler.

2. Trigger the certificate ceremony at the moment of completion

    What to change: When a user reaches 100% progress, fire the certificate ceremony immediately, the confetti, the congratulations header, the shimmer, rather than requiring the user to click "View Certificate" on the course card.

    Why: Currently, the completion moment is anticlimactic. The peak (the certificate ceremony) is delayed by one click, and the moment of completion itself produces almost no positive feedback. Three of the four participants noted this. The result is that the enrolment celebration is more memorable than the completion celebration, which is the wrong ordering, because the end of the journey is supposed to be the strongest moment.

Evidence: P1: "Nothing happened. Wait, there's a little message." P3: "The enrolment celebration fires at the moment of commitment, but the completion flow does not follow it." P4: "It feels less exciting than checkout."

Effort: Small to medium. The certificate ceremony already exists. It just needs to be triggered from the completion handler instead of from a card button click.

3. Add a clear announcement for the new "View Certificate" affordance

What to change: If the certificate ceremony is not triggered automatically (i.e., if the design keeps the "View Certificate" button as a user action), the appearance of the new button should be clearly announced, for example, with a highlighted banner or an inline message on the card.

Why: Currently, when a user reaches 100%, the "View Certificate" button appears without any visual emphasis. Two participants missed it briefly or noticed the button only after reading the toast.

Evidence: P1: "Ok there's a new 'View Certificate' button." (Paused before noticing.) P4: "Oh, no, the bar is full. Okay, there's 'View Certificate'."

Effort: Small. Either an inline message or a visual highlight on the card.

6.2 Medium priority

Changes that address lower-frequency issues or strengthen the design.

4. Add a "start here" pattern to the catalogue page

What to change: The catalogue currently presents a search bar, a sidebar with filters, a category pill row, sort controls, and a full course list at once. This is dense. Add a clear primary action like a "start with popular courses" section, or a prominent call-to-action at the top that guides users toward one obvious first step.

Why: Two of the four participants hesitated on the catalogue. P4 took twice as long as the fastest participant to complete Task 1 and described the page as having "so many options". The catalogue is functional but requires orientation. A clearer first step would reduce hesitation without reducing functionality.

Evidence: P1: "I wasn't sure whether to use the search bar or the sidebar categories." P4: "Okay, so many options."

Effort: Medium. Requires a layout addition at the top of the catalogue, but the underlying functionality stays the same.

5. Clarify the absence of a payment step at checkout

What to change: The checkout flow currently moves from cart review straight to order confirmation. Two participants expected a payment step. Add a clearly labelled note on the checkout review screen, for example, "This is a demonstration, no payment is required."

Why: Currently, the absence of a payment step is left unexplained. Users notice it, are briefly confused, and then move on. A single line of copy would resolve the confusion and reinforce that the flow is intentional.

Evidence: P2: "It didn't ask for any payment details, which is a bit weird, but this is just a test website." P3: "The missing payment step is a heuristic concern."

Effort: Very small. A single line of copy on the checkout screen.

6. Improve the course detail page's curriculum affordance

What to change: The "Curriculum" accordion on the course detail page was flagged by one participant as a non-standard pattern. Consider making it more obviously interactive, for example, by adding a chevron icon, a "Show modules" label, or a hover state that signals it can be expanded.

Why: The participant was not blocked but questioned whether users would expect the accordion. A more explicit affordance would reduce friction for less confident users.

Evidence: P3: "That's a good micro-interaction, but I wonder if users expect it. It's not a standard pattern."

Effort: Very small. A style tweak to the accordion button.

6.3 Out of scope for this iteration

Improvements that were observed but cannot be implemented in the remaining time.

7. Add a functional course player

What to change: Replace the "Complete Next Lesson (+25%)" progress simulation with a button that opens a course player, a video, a document, or a lesson interface that the user can interact with.

Why: The current progress simulation is a placeholder that allows users to advance their progress, but it does not simulate the actual experience of learning. Participants noted this: "Having a video player to 'continue' where you left off

would be more convincing." This would make the "continue learning" concept genuine rather than simulated.

Evidence: P2: "The action is still just a progress increment." P3: "A 'Continue Lesson' button that launches a course player would be a more genuine experience."

Reason out of scope: The project brief states that a full teaching system is not required. Building a course player would be a significant feature addition that extends beyond the deliverable.

The three high-priority changes are interdependent. If the certificate ceremony is triggered automatically on completion, the "announce the new button" fix becomes unnecessary. The recommended implementation is therefore:

1. Fix the toast message (regardless)
2. Trigger the certificate ceremony automatically (instead of via button click)

This pair of changes resolves the top two pain points with minimal effort.

7. Conclusion

The usability test of Create.IT was conducted with four participants across five tasks. Every participant completed every task, which confirms that the platform is functionally usable across all the journeys tested. The UEQ questionnaire results averaged 4.44 for both pragmatic and hedonic quality, with ease of use scoring highest at 5.25 and clarity scoring lowest at 3.25.

The most significant finding was a design failure at the moment of course completion. The toast message that appears at 100% progress reads "Progress updated to 0%", which all four participants noticed and three interpreted as a bug. Combined with the fact that the certificate ceremony fires one click late, the result is that the end of the learning journey, the moment the Peak-End Rule identifies as most important, currently produces the weakest positive reaction in the entire experience. This is in direct contrast to the enrolment celebration, which all four participants highlighted as a standout moment.

The recommended improvements are small in scope but high in impact. Fixing the completion toast and triggering the certificate ceremony automatically at 100% progress would resolve both of the critical pain points without requiring any new features. Two medium-priority improvements, a clearer primary action on the catalogue page and an explicit note about the no-payment checkout, would address the secondary friction points observed.

In summary, the test confirms that the design's structural choices are sound and that the celebration-based peaks work when placed at the right moments. The remaining work is a single coherent fix: move the completion peak to the moment of completion. This will align the design with the Peak-End Rule and satisfy the client's original brief that finishing a course should stand out.

Appendices

Appendix A - Observation sheet used

The following observation sheet was used to capture notes during each session. The blank template is provided below.

Date: _____ **Time started:** _____

Device used: ☐ Desktop ☐ Laptop ☐ Tablet ☐ Phone

Browser: _____

Prior course-platform experience:

☐ No experience ☐ Some experience (list): _____

TASK 1 - Find a motion graphics course, describe what they'd learn

Start time: _____ **End time:** _____ **Duration:** _____

Outcome: ☐ Completed ☐ Partial ☐ Failed

_____

First action taken (verbatim):

_____

Hesitations (where, how long, why):

_____

_____

Verbatim quote(s):

_____

Notes:

_____

_____

TASK 2 - Add course to cart and complete checkout

Start time:_____ **End time:**_____ **Duration:**_____

Outcome: ☐ Completed ☐ Partial ☐ Failed

First action taken (verbatim):

_____

Hesitations:

_____

Reaction to celebration overlay (if reached):

_____

_____

Verbatim quote(s):

_____

Notes:

_____

_____

TASK 3 - Find where to see enrolled courses

Start time:_____ **End time:**_____ **Duration:**_____

Outcome: ☐ Completed ☐ Partial ☐ Failed

First action taken (verbatim):

_____

Hesitations:

_____

Verbatim quote(s):

_____

Notes:

_____

_____

TASK 4 - Track progress / continue where they left off

Start time: _____ **End time:** _____ **Duration:** _____

Outcome: ☐ Completed ☐ Partial ☐ Failed

First action taken (verbatim):

Hesitations:

Reaction to +25% badge / milestone markers (if triggered):

Verbatim quote(s):

Notes:

TASK 5 - Get a certificate after finishing a course

Start time: _____ **End time:** _____ **Duration:** _____

Outcome: ☐ Completed ☐ Partial ☐ Failed

First action taken (verbatim):

Hesitations:

Reaction to certificate ceremony (confetti, congrats header, download):

Verbatim quote(s):

Notes:

DEBRIEF QUESTIONS (ask after all 5 tasks)

1. **Was there anything that confused you?**

2. **Was there anything that surprised you in a good way?**

3. **If you could change one thing, what would it be?**

POST-SESSION QUICK NOTES

Single biggest confusion point:

Single biggest delight moment:

One quote worth using in the report: